

How to ask for help. Without feeling like you're imposing.

Asking your network for specific, direct help is the single most effective thing you can do in a search — and the thing most candidates avoid longest.

IF YOU TAKE NOTHING ELSE AWAY

Five things that matter most

- Asking for a job is the wrong ask. Asking for a conversation, an introduction, or someone's perspective always converts better.
- People want to help — but vague asks make it impossible. 'Open to anything' is not something your contacts can act on.
- The biggest fear — that you'll damage the relationship by asking — almost never happens. Asking well actually strengthens relationships.
- Timing matters: ask early, when you're calm, not when you're desperate. Desperate asks produce different results.
- The ask should take 30 seconds to say or 3 sentences to write. If it takes longer, it's too complicated.

The most useful resource in any job search is other people — and asking them directly for what you need is the skill most candidates have the hardest time building.

The fear: you'll seem desperate, you'll damage the relationship, they'll say no and it will be awkward. The reality: people who are asked well feel good about being asked. They want to help. The ask is a gift, not a burden.

WHAT TO ASK FOR — SPECIFICALLY

Vague asks get vague responses

The conversation ask (most valuable)

"I'm targeting VP Finance roles in healthcare or fintech. Would you have 15 minutes to catch up? I'd love to hear what you've been seeing in the market and share where I'm focused." This is specific enough to be useful and easy enough to say yes to.

The introduction ask

"I noticed you're connected to [Name] at [Company]. I'm targeting that company for a [role type] position. Would you be willing to make a quick introduction? Happy to send you something brief to forward." Always send them a two-sentence version of your background they can paste into the intro email without editing.

The reference ask

"Would you be willing to be a reference for me? I'd love to have a quick call to brief you on what I'm targeting and two or three things I'd like you to highlight." Ask before companies ask — not after.

The information ask

"I'm researching [company / role type / industry]. You'd have better context than almost anyone I know. Would you have 15 minutes? I have two specific questions." Having specific questions makes the ask concrete and easy to fulfill.

WHAT NOT TO DO

The asks that don't work

- **Asking for a job directly:** "Let me know if you hear of anything" gives your contact nothing to act on. If a job opens next month they may not remember to call you. Be specific.

- **The long apologetic preamble:** "I know you're busy, and I'm sorry to bother you, and I completely understand if this isn't the right time, but..." — It signals the ask is unreasonable. If it's a reasonable ask, make it without apology.
- **Waiting until you're desperate:** Asks made from a calm, confident place produce better conversations. Asks made at month four of a search, when you need something urgently, feel different to the person receiving them.
- **Mass outreach:** Sending the same message to 30 people is detectable and produces far fewer responses than 10 personal notes that reference something specific about each relationship.

NEXTCAPTER TOOL

Victoria's Outreach Scripts generate personalized messages in your voice for every type of ask — calibrated to your anxiety level and relationship warmth. Available at launchournextchapter.com